AN ORIGINAL LITERARY MYSTERY

The Lost Manuscript

THE KEEPER’S LETTER

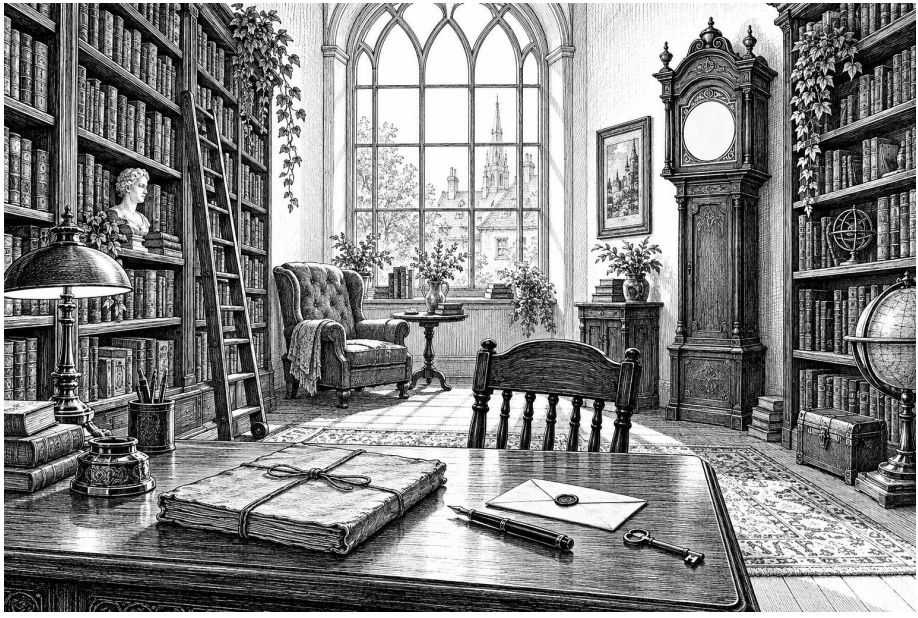


A letter. Five books. One forgotten folio.

ILLUSTRATED CASE PROOF

CASE I

The Keeper’s Letter



Bellwether Books

A letter. Five books.
One forgotten folio.

THE REOPENING

The room that kept a secret

By late afternoon, Bellwether Books will be full of people. The lamps are ready, the dust is gone, and the old reading room is opening for the first time in years. Ada Bell, the new keeper, has asked you to help with one last thing.

“Elsie left this for whoever would listen,” she says, sliding an envelope across the counter. Elsie Rowan retired last winter, after forty years of knowing which book every customer needed. She has sent a note instead of attending tonight’s opening.

For decades, the shop’s inventory has carried a curious entry: *A Map of Unwritten Hours*, an unpublished manuscript by its founder, Elias Rowan. Nobody has seen the pages. Nobody knows whether the book was ever finished.

Inside Elsie’s envelope are a five-line letter and three old records. Her instruction is brief: “Find the first folio. A direction leads to a shelf; the middle book leads to an object. My work log will tell you how to open what you find.”

TO THE NEW KEEPER

Before you open the file

You need a pencil and the following papers. Play alone, or share the evidence with another reader. Every answer can be found in these documents; no knowledge of published novels is required.



I. A five-line letter

Find the direction that points to the shelf.

II. The shelf record

Arrange five books and identify the middle one.

III. The private catalogue

Read the inscription belonging to that book.

IV. The keeper’s work log

Find the moment that opens the locked drawer.

Keep your discoveries on the recovery certificate, page 9. The keeper’s marginalia on pages 10–11 offer gradual hints. The sealed explanations and ending begin on page 12.

DOCUMENT I

Elsie’s envelope

The note has five carefully spaced lines. A pencil remark at the top reads: “Begin well, and you will know where to look.”

BELLWETHER BOOKS

To the next keeper

No story is lost while someone keeps looking.

Old shelves have longer memories than we do.

Read the room before you read its books.

There is a beginning hidden in every line.

Hold on to the direction when you find it.



Elsie Rowan

The direction in the note:

The reading room has four shelves: NORTH, EAST, SOUTH and WEST. Take your direction to the shelf record.

DOCUMENT II

The shelf record

On the shelf named by the letter, five books stand in one straight row. Reconstruct their positions from left to right, with no gaps.

VOLUMES · UNORDERED INVENTORY

The Weather Atlas · The Quiet Garden · The Dusk Letters · The Hidden River · The Glass Orchard

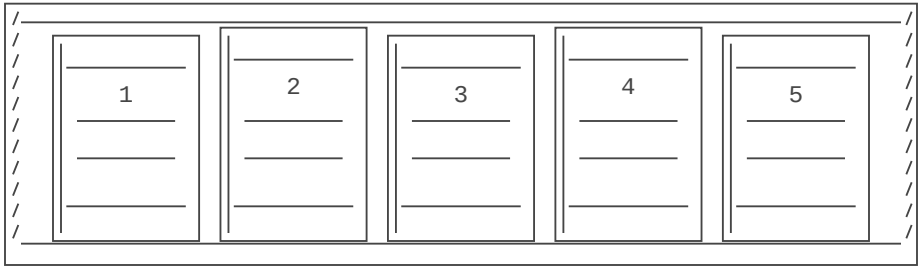
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1. The Glass Orchard is immediately to the left of The Quiet Garden.

2. The Weather Atlas is immediately to the right of The Hidden River.

3. The Quiet Garden is somewhere to the left of The Weather Atlas.

4. The Dusk Letters is somewhere to the left of The Glass Orchard.



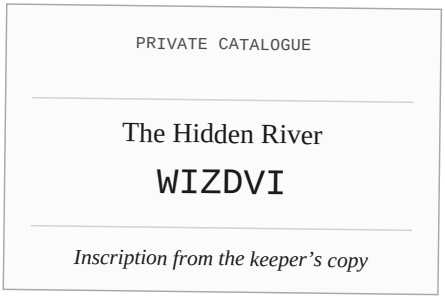
The book in the middle position:

Only its catalogue inscription points to the next object.

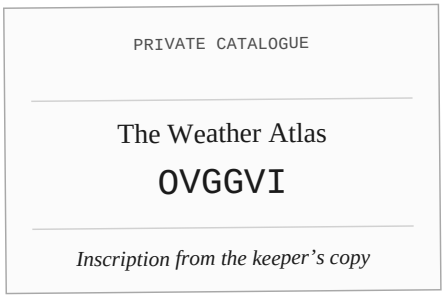
DOCUMENT III

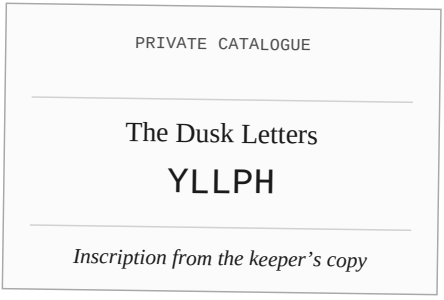
The private catalogue

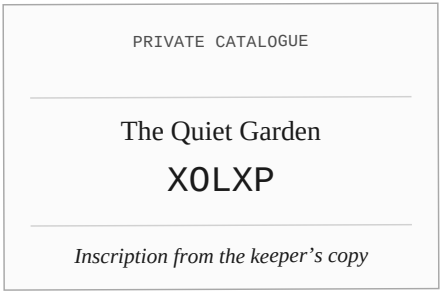
Elsie kept a small card for each book. Select the card belonging to the middle book, then turn to her alphabet note.











The catalogue order is not the shelf order.

DOCUMENT III · CONTINUED

Words facing the mirror

A slip pinned to the catalogue reads:

“Pair the alphabet’s first letter with its last, its second with its second-last, and so on. Replace each letter in the inscription with its partner.”

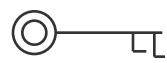
THE COMPLETE ALPHABET

A	B	C	D	E	F	G	H	I	J	K	L	M
N	O	P	Q	R	S	T	U	V	W	X	Y	Z

Use the inscription from the middle book’s card. Its decoded word names an object in the reading room. Elsie says the object’s wooden base contains a small locked drawer.

The inscription I selected:

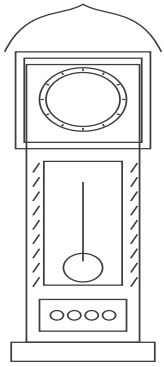
The object it names:



DOCUMENT IV

The keeper’s work log

A label inside the wooden base refers to Elsie’s log. The drawer has a four-digit combination.



“I began at 09:45. These tasks followed one another, in the listed order, with no overlaps or other breaks. After the final task, I set the combination to the time I finished.”

WORK COMPLETED IN ORDER

Polish the archive plates	22 min
Replace the shelf labels	17 min
Wrap the light-sensitive papers	26 min
Inspect the wooden base	15 min

Write the finishing time in 24-hour form. Remove the colon, keeping both hour digits and both minute digits.

Finishing time

Four-digit combination

THE DISCOVERY

Archive recovery certificate

Complete the route before opening the sealed explanations. Each discovery should be supported by one of the documents.

Direction given by the letter

Book in the middle of the shelf

Object named by its inscription

Drawer combination

How the papers led me here:



A nudge is waiting in the keeper’s marginalia, pages 10–11. When you are ready, the explanations and ending begin on page 12.

OPTIONAL HELP

The keeper’s marginalia

Read one hint at a time; pause before the next.

The letter

1. Focus on the five printed lines, rather than the signature or the pencil remark.

2. Elsie mentions a beginning. What stands at the beginning of each of those five lines?

3. Take their first letters from top to bottom. Together they spell one of the four compass directions.

The shelf

1. Treat each “immediately” clue as a two-book block that cannot be split.

2. The Glass Orchard / Quiet Garden block must come before the Hidden River / Weather Atlas block.

3. The Dusk Letters must be before The Glass Orchard. Put it before both two-book blocks, then identify position three.

OPTIONAL HELP

The keeper’s marginalia

Read one hint at a time; pause before the next.

The catalogue

1. Start with the inscription belonging to the middle book, rather than decoding every card.

2. The alphabet is mirrored: A pairs with Z, B with Y, C with X, and so on.

3. The first two letters of XOLXP decode to C and L. Keep applying the same rule to the remaining letters.

The work log

1. The combination uses the finishing time. All four durations must be included.

2. The tasks take 80 minutes altogether. Add that to 09:45.

3. Add one hour first, then another twenty minutes. Write the resulting time with two hour digits and two minute digits, without a colon.

SEALED PAPERS · SPOILERS

The complete route

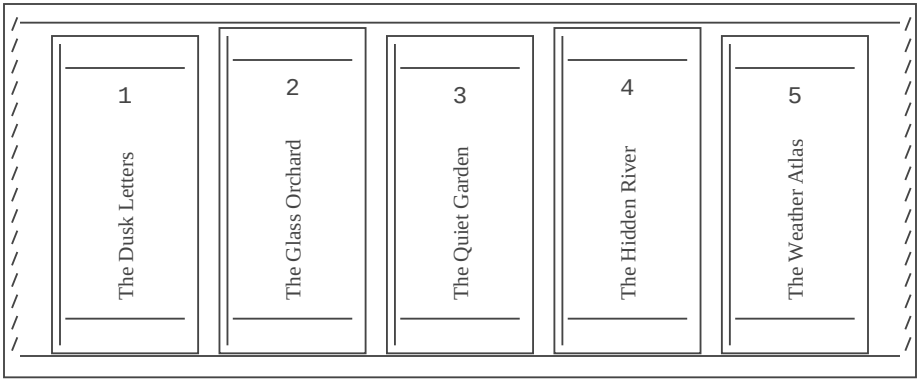
NORTH · THE QUIET GARDEN

CLOCK · 1105

The letter

The five lines start with **N, O, R, T, H**. In order, the initials point to the NORTH shelf. The reference to a “beginning” directs attention to the first letters.

The shelf



The adjacent pairs are Glass Orchard / Quiet Garden and Hidden River / Weather Atlas. The first pair must precede the second, and Dusk Letters must precede Glass Orchard. These conditions fix the row. Its middle book is **The Quiet Garden**.

SEALED PAPERS · CONTINUED

The object and combination

The catalogue

The Quiet Garden’s inscription is **XOLXP**. Mirroring the alphabet gives X → C, O → L, L → O, X → C and P → K: **CLOCK**. The drawer is in the clock’s wooden base.

The work log

Start	`09:45`
Archive plates: +22 minutes	`10:07`
Shelf labels: +17 minutes	`10:24`
Wrapped papers: +26 minutes	`10:50`
Wooden base: +15 minutes	`11:05`

The tasks take 80 minutes. The finishing time is **11:05**. Removing the colon gives **1105**; both minute digits are required.

The first folio is in the drawer beneath the reading-room clock. The papers identify its shelf, book and object before providing the combination.

EPILOGUE

The first unwritten hour

The brass wheels settle beneath your fingertips. For a moment, nothing moves. Then the latch gives, softly enough to be mistaken for another tick.

Inside the clock’s base is a narrow paper parcel. Ada lifts it into the lamplight. The ribbon leaves a clean stripe across the brown wrapping, as if the years have collected everywhere except the place someone took care to protect.

There is one title page, written in a small, deliberate hand: *A Map of Unwritten Hours*. Below it stands the name Elias Rowan. A pencilled sentence waits at the bottom: “For anyone who has ever found the right door inside the wrong book.”

A second note is in Elsie’s hand. “People called the manuscript lost because they were looking for one finished object. Elias left it in six gatherings. This is the first. I kept his trail because I wanted the next keeper to discover the shop as he did: by paying attention.”

Ada turns the page. The first paragraph describes a city whose library lends hours instead of books. An hour of courage. An hour of forgiveness. An hour to say what should have been said before the door closed.

Outside, the evening’s first visitor pauses beneath the shop sign. Ada carefully lays the folio on the archive table. There are five more gatherings to find. For tonight, though, the oldest story in Bellwether Books has finally reached a reader.

A Map of Unwritten Hours

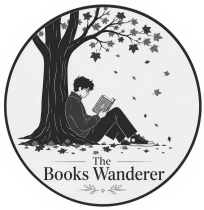
by Elias Rowan

There was a city where the library lent hours instead of books. Its shelves held small, plain volumes with names such as *An Hour of Courage* and *An Hour to Begin Again*. Nobody was allowed to borrow an hour for another person, and nobody could keep one past sunrise.

On the morning the clocks stopped, a girl named Mara returned an empty volume. The librarian turned it over twice. “What did you do with the hour?” he asked. Mara looked towards the door, where someone had been waiting for a very long time. “I listened,” she said.



The first folio is safe.
Five gatherings remain.



The Books Wanderer

Stories for curious readers

THE LOST MANUSCRIPT

Case I · The Keeper’s Letter

English editorial proof
First case of a planned six-case book

This prototype contains original fictional people, places and documents. It is a case proof for reader testing; the complete book is in development.

thebookswanderer.com